THE MIDNIGHT FRIENDSHIP SERVICE

The moon stared down on New Mandalay with the kind of resentment that kept one up at midnight. The refined, or so they said, city buildings poked into the atmosphere and competed with her children in the sky as each structure tried to outshine the other. It was in folklore that they, the humans, used to eulogize the death of each star, awarding them titles, assembling them into constellations, and worshipping... the dimmest of lights. Now, her eternal punishment was to watch them all die, one by one, competing to shine in a hopeless world, exploding and killing themselves. For nothing.

The golden days were gone. Culture had fallen. And, all that remained was...

"... THE MIDNIGHT FRIENDSHIP SERVICE! Welcome. I am Dawn. Can I create a friend for you tonight?" a happy, machinelike voice emerged from the other side of the phone.

Alice took a breath in. Breathing out, she replied, "Yes, please. Can I request for someone not too... umm... robotic? I don't mean to be rude. I just..."

The voice interrupted (still cheery), "No worries! We are a service catering to all your needs. Just hang on tight. We will create one for you very soon. Good luck!"

And, Dawn was gone. Music played in the background as Alice waited. A chilling breeze brushed over her whole body as she stood facing the moon. Her thoughts were everywhere, but present. The shopping mall music. That's what they used to call this type of tune. Back when the shopping malls were a thing. Back when everything wasn't delivered to her 99-story-high apartment (the law forbids building higher than 99 floors for safety reasons and to "preserve the environment".), and school, and all other meetings, weren't online. She envied the kids who played in shopping malls through her favorite movies from centuries ago. Now, she had never met one not through the screen but her own eyes in her whole life. Oh, what she would give to leave this apartment complex...

"Hello?" a voice called out from the other side of the phone. Alice jumped. Before she could reply, the voice introduced himself. "Hey, are you there? I am Ollie... Are you my robot friend? Did they finish creating you? Can we talk now?"

"Hey," Alice replied, confused. "I am Alice. Nice to meet you."

"Oh, hey Alice!" Pause. "I am kinda nervous. I have never called THE MIDNIGHT FRIENDSHIP SERVICE before. What do we talk about? How do we start? Are you supposed to be like my AI therapist or something?"

Alice was stunned. She did not know how to respond. Something seemed off

"Hey, can you hear me? Did the line cut off?"

"I am here," Alice finally replied.

"Oh, good. Should I talk to you about my problems now?"

"Ummm… I am… not a robot or an AI assistant. I am just like you. Looking for someone to talk to."

"Wait…" There was a pause. "So, you are also a HUMAN?!" Ollie responded. Alice can feel the shock spilling through the sound waves.

"Yes…"

"And, you are also not OLD?!" Ollie continued.

"Well, I am 19."

"WOWWWW…. I am 19, too! I thought we went extinct!"

"Nope. My parents still decided to have me. Intentionally. I haven't seen anyone as crazy as them my whole life. No one younger than 40 in my apartment complex."

"Well, I was an accident. But you know… I am glad to be alive. Life is fun!"

"I'm happy for you," Alice responded softly.

"So, where are you right now?" Ollie attempted to change the topic.

"Umm… I live in the Grand Palm neighborhood. New Mandalay."

"That's so cool! I am from West Woods."

"Oh, I thought that was a wasteland, populated only with machines. Did you get lost?"

"Nope. That's my home! Not a big fancy building, but it can be cozy." Alice could feel Ollie's smile radiating through his voice. "Well, I sometimes do wonder what my life would be like if I was born somewhere like the Grand Palm though."

"I can tell you from up here that it's… not the best," Alice tried to match his energy, but failed. "You get tired of the view very quickly. All the billboards filled with the richest brands. The blandest music. Politicians. Movie stars. Video games. Gambling cults. Online sex clubs. Everyone here is fighting to shine and all these lights. They get so overwhelming sometimes."

"I can only imagine," Ollie replied, a little less cheery. "...Wait. What do you mean up here?"

"The rooftop. I am now sitting on a pipe, just trying to pass time."

"Are you okay?"

"Are you? You sound pretty jolly. Why did you call the 'AI therapist' hotline?"

"I am fine," Ollie paused. Seven seconds, Alice counted. It was the longest he had gone without talking.

"I am just a bit overwhelmed… My mom passed away two days ago. It's just me and my dad now. I have no friends here. No light to see. No music. No video games. Just a dark swamp."

A chill wind struck again, reminding Alice of why she was there. She stood up, stared at the moon, and gave Ollie an affirming nod, forgetting he couldn't see her.

Ollie continued, "I just miss her on nights like these." The light seemingly disappeared from Ollie's voice. Alice let out an audible sigh as she took a step toward the moon.

"Are YOU okay?" Ollie asked after about seven seconds.

"Yeah. I am sorry about your mom. I can relate. Very well."

"Oh… I am sorry."

"No. Don't be. It's already been two years," said Alice, taking another step. "I wish I could comfort you, but I am fucked up myself."

"No worries," replied Ollie with her newfound spark. "I just wanted someone to talk to. And, you. are. perfect!"

Alice took another step forward, letting the silence take over the conversation for a few seconds. She felt way closer to those bright buildings she described before. There were only a few spaces of buffer before she'd run out of steps she could take now.

Alice finally responded,

"Hey Ollie, have you ever thought about killing yourself?"

There was a pause. Five seconds.

"You mean like... suicide?" Ollie stuttered.

"Yeah," replied Alice nonchalantly. She continued moving forward.

"I mean I have thought about it. Yes."

Alice reached the ledge (It was the height that made one wonder if anyone planning these buildings even cared about the safety of its residents.) She had no trouble climbing on it. It was just a few feet difference, but she felt the wind lighter as she stood on that ledge.

"Yeah, I do miss my mom, and sometimes I think about it. But, I would never easily throw away this life she gave me," Ollie continued, finding strength back in his voice.

"But, do you ever feel like life will never be better?"

"Yes, I am a bit down right now, but I am happy in this life. Like mom always told me: Happiness is found. The brightest star can only lead South. But, the explorer finds the wonders of the world by making use of all the stars in the sky. He controls the direction of his life. Happiness follows."

There was a pause. Six seconds. This time, Alice broke it, "Your mom sounds very wise and caring."

"...Are you okay, Alice?"

Alice looked down and all she saw was light. She then looked up. Just a half-full moon, bent upside down. No stars left in the sky. She looked back down. Everything was bright. She wondered if the ground existed at all. Would she finally shine a bit if she finally took the step? The thoughts cluttered her mind. Tears fell as the distress signal flares.

"Ollie..." whimpered Alice. "My mind spirals, Ollie. And, and, sometimes, the noise gets loud. I need a friend. But, there is no one close to my age in this apartment. And, we can't go out because there are only criminals out there or something. But, everything is online including school and I have never seen the faces of my classmates. And, all the robots deliver everything, do everything, help with everything. But, I just wanted a friend. Someone to talk to."

"I am here, Alice. I can be your friend." Ollie cheered her up. "I'll be your AI therapist! Your very own midnight friendship service!"

Alice chuckled. A genuine smile flashed across her face. If happiness was infectious, it must be airborne, and through the sound waves.

"I never had a conversation as long as this with anyone. I knew this was what I had been missing. What I needed. But, I couldn't find it anywhere."

"I feel the same,"

"It's just... I mean It is eye-opening to meet someone like you who keeps a positive attitude in times like these."

"I try," Ollie responded with a hint of jest.

"Heck, it seems like your situation is even worse than mine. But, here I am, dwelling in my pain, complaining about life. Contemplating..." Alice stopped.

"What are you doing Alice? Can you tell me? Are you okay?" Ollie questioned, worried.

Silence fell again. Eight seconds.

"I wasn't sure if I wanted to live in this place. The older I got, the clearer it was for me why there aren't more young people like me anymore. No sane mother could bear the pain of bringing up a child in a world where no one else would appreciate their life. No space to grow. Nowhere to shine." Alice paused to let out a sigh. She continued, "I was about to jump, and maybe fly to the moon."

Silence fell. A chilling wind brushed across Alice's cheeks. She stood on the ledge. She stared into the dark night sky. It stared right back into her. She suddenly saw a flicker in the sky. A small light, twinkling. She made a decision. She took a step... backward. She whispered into the phone,

"But, don't worry. I don't think I will go through with it anymore."

"... I am sorry. I didn't know what to say or how..."

Alice interrupted, "You didn't need to. You've already helped me. I needed someone in my life. And, it is nice to meet someone stronger than me. It makes some obstacles seem a bit less small."

"Alice... I don't know what to say. All I know is that I like talking to you. And, I agree... one of the best conversations I had."

"Me too," Alice nodded in agreement. After a few seconds, she continued, "Who knew this accidental mix-up would have changed my mind?"

"I agree!" Ollie responded, as bright as the cartoon characters from Alice's favorite vintage animated movies.

"Hey, Ollie. I have a worry that you might not be real," noted Alice with a smile. "I am worried that you might be the one Dawn created for me. Some sort of twisted AI therapist."

"You know what? I had the same worry!" Ollie exclaimed. "But, I don't care!" Ollie announced. "You also helped me lots. A midnight friend and a deep conversation. That's real enough for me."

Alice laughed, "Ollie, I am up here staring at all the buildings and screens and drones, but you are the brightest one shining. And, this is the brightest feeling I've ever felt. Thank you!"

"I am somewhat of a star myself," Ollie joked.

"I don't know when they will cut the line, but can we keep talking?"

"I would love to. Definitely. It'd be my pleasure!"

The moon shined her dim light over Alice as the call continued. She acted as a spotlight for this type of smile and laughter she hadn't witnessed in humans in a while. Listening in on the two friends, she got infected and couldn't stop but smile herself. The conversation carried on till dawn arrived. It was time for her to leave, so she saved her resentments for another night. Right after, the sun would rise slowly to show humanity who still shined the brightest.